

A

Letters or words?

Most abbreviations are spoken as individual letters.

- EU** European Union
- UN** United Nations
- PM** Prime Minister
- MP** Member of Parliament
- BBC** British Broadcasting Corporation
- ID** identification, e.g. Do you have an ID card?
- PC** personal computer
- CV** curriculum vitae [a history of your job experience]
- ISP** Internet Service Provider



Occasionally abbreviations are spoken as words, e.g. **AIDS** /eɪdz/ and **PIN** /pɪn/ [personal identification number, especially used with a bank/credit card]

Language help

We use the verb **stand for** to ask about the meaning of an abbreviation.

A: **What does** EU **stand for**?

B: European Union.

B

Written forms only

Some abbreviations are written forms only, but pronounced as full words.

- Mr** Scott (mister Scott) **St** Mark's Church (Saint Mark's Church)
- Mrs** Bryant (misses Bryant) Dean **St** (Dean Street)
- Dr** Chapman (doctor Chapman)

C

Abbreviations as part of the language

Some abbreviations (from Latin) are used as part of the language.

Latin	abbreviation	pronunciation	meaning
et cetera	etc.	/et 'setərə/	and so on
exempli gratia	e.g.	/ɪ'ɹdʒi:/	for example
id est	i.e.	/aɪ'i:/	that's to say / in other words

D

Shortened words

Some common English words can be shortened, especially in spoken English. In some cases, the shorter form is more common and the full form sounds quite formal, e.g. refrigerator, influenza, gymnasium and veterinary surgeon.

- phone** (telephone)
- maths** (mathematics)
- board** (whiteboard/smartboard/blackboard)
- case** (suitcase)
- ad/advert** (advertisement)
- gym** (gymnasium)
- bike** (bicycle)
- TV/telly** (television)
- paper** (newspaper)
- fridge** (refrigerator)
- exam** (examination)
- plane** (aeroplane)
- photo** (photograph)
- flu** (influenza) [illness like a cold but more serious]
- lab** (laboratory) [special room where scientists work]
- sales rep** (sales representative; *syn* **salesperson**)
- vet** (veterinary surgeon)